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GABOCHIE DESIGN

The Ghana Building Project Readiness Checklist

The 40-point checklist we walk every project through — before a single cedi is committed.

40 POINTS · 8 STAGES

Most building problems in Ghana are not construction problems. They are decision problems — land purchased without verification, designs drawn without cost, contractors chosen without a fair process, approvals started without documentation.

This checklist is the order of operations we use when we take on a project. Work through it honestly, in sequence, and you will know exactly where your project stands — and exactly what to fix before you commit money.

— The Gabochie Design team · Design. Value. Transformation.

> **How to use it:** Tick each point only when you can prove it, not when you intend to do it. Every unticked box is a risk — price it, or fix it, before you build. If any stage is unclear, that is the first thing to resolve.

1 Land & Title

STAGE: FOUNDATION

- [ ] **Ownership proven.** You can show who owns the land — title certificate, indenture, or allocation letter — and it matches the seller.
- [ ] **No dispute or double sale.** You have verified the land is not subject to an active dispute, court case, or double sale.
- [ ] **Boundaries confirmed.** You have a site plan showing the exact plot size and boundaries, agreed with neighbours.
- [ ] **Zoning checked.** You know the planning zone and what the land legally permits you to build.
- [ ] **Registration status known.** You know whether the land is registered with the Lands Commission — or what it takes to register it.

2 Vision & Feasibility

STAGE: CLARITY

- [ ] **One clear sentence.** You can describe what you want to build — use, size, and location — in a single sentence.
- [ ] **Users defined.** You know who will use the building and how, not just what it should look like.
- [ ] **Feasibility tested.** You have tested whether the project makes sense for your land, budget, and timeline — not just whether it excites you.
- [ ] **Alternatives considered.** You have weighed the alternatives — including not building yet — with the same rigour.
- [ ] **Budget ceiling set.** You know your budget ceiling and have separated it from your ideal figure.

3 Budget & Cost

STAGE: COST INTELLIGENCE

- [ ] **Full-project estimate.** You have a credible estimate for the whole project — not just the building itself.
- [ ] **All costs included.** The estimate covers design, approvals, site works, utilities, and professional fees.
- [ ] **Contingency held.** You have set aside a realistic contingency — 10% is the norm in Ghana, not a luxury.
- [ ] **Fixed vs. moving costs.** You know which costs are fixed (design, permits) and which move with the market (materials, labour).
- [ ] **Currency risk understood.** You understand how exchange rates and material price shifts will hit your budget.

4 Design & Drawings

STAGE: DESIGN

- [ ] **Right designer.** You have engaged an architect or designer whose portfolio matches your project type and budget.
- [ ] **Written brief.** The designer is working from a written brief — not from conversations.
- [ ] **Buildable drawings.** The design is coordinated: structural, electrical, and plumbing are resolved in the drawings.
- [ ] **Cost-checked design.** You have seen the design checked against cost before committing to detailed drawings.
- [ ] **Complete set.** You have a full drawing set suitable for pricing and approval — not a sketch.

5 Approvals & Permits

STAGE: APPROVALS

- [ ] **Requirements known.** You know exactly which approvals your project needs — planning, building, environmental.
- [ ] **Documents ready.** Your drawings are prepared for submission — not improvised at the counter.
- [ ] **Fees and time budgeted.** You have budgeted for approval fees and allowed the time in your schedule.
- [ ] **Constraints known.** You know your site's compliance constraints — setbacks, height, heritage, easements.
- [ ] **Process owned.** You have decided who manages approvals — you, or a professional who will see it through.

6 Contractor & Procurement

STAGE: PROCUREMENT

- [ ] **Fair competition.** You have a clear scope of work that at least three contractors will price identically.
- [ ] **Track record checked.** You have verified each contractor's past projects — not just their quote.
- [ ] **Like-for-like comparison.** Your evaluation compares scope, materials, and payment terms — not just the bottom line.
- [ ] **Written contract.** You have a signed contract with defined scope, schedule, and payment milestones.
- [ ] **Change process agreed.** You know how variations and extras will be priced — before they happen.

7 Construction Readiness

STAGE: DELIVERY

- [ ] **Site services ready.** Your site has water, power, and secure access before the first truck arrives.
- [ ] **Materials strategy.** You have agreed who buys materials — and how quality and price are checked.
- [ ] **Milestone payments.** Your payment schedule is tied to verified progress, not calendar dates alone.
- [ ] **Supervision appointed.** Someone independent supervises the site if you cannot be there — no exceptions.
- [ ] **Reporting cadence set.** You have agreed how often you receive progress reports and what they contain.

8 Delivery & Control

STAGE: COMPLETION

- [ ] **Progress vs. drawings.** Work is tracked against the drawings — not just against time.
- [ ] **Cost alerts.** Overruns are flagged as they happen, and you know who has the authority to stop.
- [ ] **Documented trail.** You keep a record of decisions, payments, and site instructions.
- [ ] **Handover planned.** The finishing sequence is planned so handover is smooth — not rushed.
- [ ] **Snagging process.** You have a defects and snagging process before releasing the final payment.

Not sure where your project stands?

We take projects from the first question to the final snagging pass. Bring us your checklist — we'll show you exactly what's ready and what isn't.

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